

PEACHES AND NECTARINES

Prunus persica and *Prunus persica* var. *nectarina*

Sweet, juicy, and delicious, fuzzy peaches and smooth nectarines are delicious eaten fresh or used for making jams or desserts. Requiring cold weather over winter, protection from frost in spring, and sun in summer, peaches and nectarines are fussy trees, but try growing them in movable containers so that you can guarantee them the conditions they'll need.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
PLANT				
HARVEST				

PLANTING

Peaches and nectarines need a warm, sheltered site: a south-facing wall is ideal if you are growing them outside; they can then be easily protected against frost, predators, and rain with fleece, netting, or plastic sheeting. They will grow happily under cover in a greenhouse, and some types are suitable for containers so can be moved indoors or out as the weather dictates. Peaches and nectarines prefer a deep, slightly acidic soil—a pH of between 6.5 and 7 is ideal—that does not become waterlogged; plant both types in fall or early spring.

Prepare your plot by digging in well-rotted manure or compost a few months before planting. Trees can be purchased either



Plant in a sheltered site to protect blossoms.

bare-root or container-grown. If you buy container-grown trees, ensure that they have not become pot-bound. Plant both types between fall and early spring, to the same depth as the soil mark on their stems.

If you are training your tree against a wall, fix the horizontal wires before planting. Trees will need staking for a few years; insert a stake before planting.